

ReaCustomMenu Version 1.0.0

User Manual

Compatibility: Windows only

ReaCustomMenu is currently available for **Windows only**. There is currently no macOS or Linux version.

1. Introduction

ReaCustomMenu is a REAPER extension that allows you to create your own menus in REAPER's main menu bar.

You can create, for example:

- a "Mixing" menu
- a "MIDI" menu
- a "Scripts" menu
- submenus
- separators
- shortcuts to REAPER actions
- shortcuts to your ReaScripts
- shortcuts to SWS actions

Menus created by ReaCustomMenu remain available in REAPER and do not depend on REAPER's "Customize Menus/Toolbars" system.

The configuration is stored in a file called:

`ReaCustomMenu.xml`

XML Notepad is recommended for editing this file. It lets you work with the file as a tree structure instead of having to edit the XML text directly.

You do not need to know XML to use ReaCustomMenu with XML Notepad.

2. Installation

Installation simply consists of putting two files in the correct locations:

- `reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll`
- `ReaCustomMenu.xml`

2.1 Finding the REAPER resource folder

The easiest way is to let REAPER open it for you.

1. Start REAPER.
2. In REAPER's main menu, click "Options".
3. In the menu that appears, click:
"Show REAPER resource path in explorer/finder"

Windows will automatically open the folder used by REAPER for its personal files.

This is the folder you need for the ReaCustomMenu installation.

3. Installing the DLL

In the folder that has just opened, look for a folder called:

UserPlugins

Open it.

Copying the DLL

Copy:

reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll

into the UserPlugins folder.

You should end up with:

UserPlugins\reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll

Do not place the DLL in REAPER's installation folder, such as C:\Program Files\REAPER.

It must be placed in the UserPlugins folder inside REAPER's resource folder.

4. Installing ReaCustomMenu.xml

Return to the REAPER resource folder that you opened in section 2.

It is **this folder**, not the UserPlugins folder, that must contain:

ReaCustomMenu.xml

Copy:

ReaCustomMenu.xml

directly into this folder.

You should end up with something similar to:

REAPER resource folder

```
|
|— ReaCustomMenu.xml
|
|— UserPlugins
    |
    |— reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll
```

The names of the other files in the folder are not important.

5. Installation End

Close REAPER completely.

ReaCustomMenu reads `ReaCustomMenu.xml` when REAPER starts.

If the file is valid, the menus it contains will appear in REAPER's main menu bar.

If `ReaCustomMenu.xml` is not present, ReaCustomMenu simply creates no menus.

6. XML Notepad

6.1 Is XML Notepad required?

No. XML Notepad is not required.

If you already know XML, you can edit `ReaCustomMenu.xml` with any text editor.

However, if you do not know XML, **XML Notepad is strongly recommended.**

It lets you edit the file as a tree structure, making it much easier to create and organize menus.

XML Notepad is **free** and available for Windows. It is an open-source project developed by Microsoft.

6.2 Where can XML Notepad be downloaded?

XML Notepad is free and developed by Microsoft.

The easiest way to install it is to use the official installation page:

<https://microsoft.github.io/XmlNotepad/install/>

Simply click the installation link provided on that page and follow the instructions.

You do not need to use the Microsoft Store.

6.3 Why use XML Notepad?

XML Notepad displays the file as a tree.

You can therefore see menus and their commands one below another and modify them without having to write the XML directly.

XML Notepad can also report errors in the document.

The rest of this manual therefore describes all operations using the **XML Notepad** interface.

7. Opening the file

Start XML Notepad.

In XML Notepad:

1. Click "File".
2. Click "Open".
3. Select:
`ReaCustomMenu.xml`
from the REAPER resource folder.

The file will appear as a tree.

8. Creating your first menu

We will create a menu called:

Mixing

8.1 Select the starting point

In the XML Notepad tree, click:

menus

8.2 Add the menu

With menus selected:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
3. A new entry appears.
4. Give it the name:

mainmenu

You have now created a new main menu.

9. Naming the menu

Select `mainmenu`.

To add its name:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
3. A new attribute appears.
4. Give it the name:

`name`

5. Enter on the right pane:

`Mixing`

This is the name that will appear in REAPER's main menu bar.

10. Giving the menu an ID

Each main menu must also have its own identifier.

With `mainmenu` selected:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new attribute the name:

`id`

4. Enter in ther right pane, for example:

`mixing`

The ID is simply an internal name used by `ReaCustomMenu` to distinguish the different main menus.

You can choose the ID yourself.

For example:

`mixing`

`midi`

`scripts`

`tools`

The ID must simply be different for every main menu.

11. Adding a REAPER action

We will now add a first command to the "Mixing" menu.

Select `mainmenu`.

To add an action:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new element the name:

`action`

12. Specifying which action to run

With `action` selected:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new attribute the name:

`command`

4. Enter the REAPER action's Command ID in the right pane.

For example:

`40044`

Replace this example with the Command ID of the action you actually want to use.

13. Finding a REAPER action's Command ID

To find an action's identifier:

1. In REAPER, open the "Actions" menu.
2. Choose "Show action list".
3. Find the action you want.
4. Right click on the action name and choose "Copy Selected Action Command ID" in the drop down menu that appears on screen.

The Command ID is then ready to be pasted into XLM Notepad.

14. Using the normal name of a REAPER action

For a standard REAPER action, you normally do not need to specify its name.

REAPER already knows the action name and will display it automatically.

This is therefore the recommended method for native REAPER actions.

15. Giving an action a custom name

You can replace the displayed name with a name of your choice.

With `action` selected:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new attribute the name:

`name`

4. Enter in the right pane, for example:

`Open Mixer`

The menu will display this name instead of the normal action name.

16. Adding a ReaScript

ReaCustomMenu can also run your ReaScripts.

In REAPER's Action List, a ReaScript normally has a Command ID beginning with:

`_RS`

To use one:

1. Select the menu where you want to place the script.
2. Click "Insert".
3. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
4. Create an `action` element.
5. Select the action.
6. Click "Insert".
7. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
8. Create the `command` attribute.

9. Enter the script's Command ID in the right pane.

You can then add a custom name in the same way:

"Insert" → "Attributes" → "Child"

and create the `name` attribute.

For ReaScripts, a custom name is recommended so that the menu remains clear and readable.

17. Adding an SWS action

If you use the SWS extension, its commands can also be used.

The Command ID normally begins with:

`_SWS`

Proceed in exactly the same way as for a ReaScript:

1. Add an `action` element using "Insert" → "Element" → "Child".
 2. Add the `command` attribute using "Insert" → "Attributes" → "Child".
 3. Enter the SWS Command ID.
 4. If necessary, add a `name` attribute in the same way.
-

18. Adding a separator

A separator lets you visually divide groups of commands.

Select the menu where you want to place the separator.

Then:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new element the name:

`separator`

No other information is required.

19. Creating a submenu

For example, we will create a submenu called:

`FX`

inside the:

Mixing

menu.

To do this:

1. Select the Mixing menu.
2. Click "Insert".
3. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
4. Give the new element the name:

menu

5. With menu selected, click "Insert".
6. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
7. Give the new attribute the name:

name

8. Enter in the right pane:

FX

The "FX" menu now appears as a submenu of "Mixing".

20. Adding commands to a submenu

Select the FX submenu.

To add an action:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new element the name:

action

4. Select the action.
5. Click "Insert".
6. In the "Attributes" submenu, choose "Child".
7. Add the command attribute.
8. Enter the required Command ID.

You can repeat this operation as many times as necessary.

21. Adding a separator to a submenu

Select the submenu concerned.

Then:

1. Click "Insert".
2. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
3. Give the new element the name:

separator

22. Creating a submenu inside another submenu

Submenus can contain other submenus.

For example:

Mixing

FX

Dynamics

Compressors

Limiters

Equalization

EQ 1

EQ 2

To create another level:

1. Select the submenu where you want to add the new submenu.
2. Click "Insert".
3. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
4. Give the new element the name:

menu

5. Add its name attribute using "Insert" → "Attributes" → "Child".

There is no fixed number of submenu levels imposed by ReaCustomMenu.

23. Moving an entry

You can change the order of commands by moving entries in the XML Notepad tree.

You can use drag and drop when XML Notepad allows the selected item to be moved.

The order of entries in the tree corresponds to their order in the REAPER menu.

24. Deleting an entry

To delete an action, separator or submenu:

1. Select the entry in the tree.
2. Use XML Notepad's delete command.

If you delete a submenu, all commands contained in that submenu are also removed from the configuration.

25. Creating a second main menu

You can create as many main menus as you need.

To create another main menu:

1. Select menus.
2. Click "Insert".
3. In the "Element" submenu, choose "Child".
4. Give the new element the name:

`mainmenu`

5. Add its name attribute using "Insert" → "Attributes" → "Child".
6. Enter, for example:

`MIDI`

7. Add its `id` attribute in the same way.
8. Enter, for example:

`midi`

You can then add actions and submenus to this new menu.

26. Saving your changes

When your menu is finished:

1. In XML Notepad, click "File".
2. Choose "Save".

You can then close XML Notepad.

27. Applying the changes in REAPER

ReaCustomMenu reads its configuration when REAPER starts.

After modifying and saving `ReaCustomMenu.xml`:

1. Close REAPER.
2. Wait until REAPER has completely closed.
3. Start REAPER again.

Your changes should now appear.

28. Main menu IDs

Every main menu must have a different ID.

For example:

Mixing → mixing

MIDI → midi

Scripts → scripts

Do not give the same ID to two main menus.

If two menus use the same ID, ReaCustomMenu considers the configuration invalid and creates no menus.

29. Command IDs

ReaCustomMenu cannot guess which action you want to run.

You must provide the correct Command ID.

For a REAPER action, obtain it from:

Actions → Show action list

For a ReaScript, use its Command ID.

For an SWS action, use its SWS Command ID.

An unknown command is ignored by ReaCustomMenu and a warning is written to the log file.

30. Custom names

A custom name is optional.

For standard REAPER actions, you can normally let REAPER display the action's normal name automatically.

For ReaScripts and SWS commands, it is recommended to specify a custom name so that the menu remains readable.

The custom name does not change the command that is executed.

It only changes the text displayed in the menu.

31. If the configuration file is missing

If `ReaCustomMenu.xml` does not exist in the REAPER resource folder:

- the extension can still load normally;
- no menus are created;
- nothing interrupts REAPER's startup.

You can therefore install the DLL before creating your configuration.

32. If the configuration contains an error

`ReaCustomMenu` checks the configuration before creating the menus.

If the file contains a significant error:

- no menus are created;
 - REAPER continues to operate normally;
 - no dialog box interrupts startup;
 - an error is written to the log file.
-

33. The log file

If you encounter a problem, `ReaCustomMenu` may create:

`ReaCustomMenu.log`

This file is located in the same REAPER resource folder as `ReaCustomMenu.xml`.

To find this folder:

1. Open REAPER.
2. Click "Options".
3. Click "Show REAPER resource path in explorer/finder".

The `ReaCustomMenu.log` file is located in the folder that opens.

The log contains only errors and warnings useful for troubleshooting.

34. Checking a command problem

If a menu appears but one of its commands does not work:

1. Open REAPER's Action List.
2. Find the action concerned.
3. Check its Command ID.
4. Compare it with the one used in ReaCustomMenu.

A single incorrect letter or number is enough for the command not to be found.

For ReaScripts and SWS commands, also check that the relevant script or extension is installed and loaded in REAPER.

35. Checking an installation problem

If no menu appears:

First check

Make sure:

`ReaCustomMenu.xml`

is in the REAPER resource folder.

It must not be inside `UserPlugins`.

Second check

Make sure:

`reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll`

is in:

`UserPlugins`

Third check

Restart REAPER completely.

Fourth check

Check:

`ReaCustomMenu.log`

in the REAPER resource folder.

36. XML Notepad reports an error

XML Notepad may report an error in the file.

Use the information provided by XML Notepad to locate the problem.

An error may prevent ReaCustomMenu from loading the entire configuration.

If you do not know XML, it is often easier to return to the XML Notepad tree and check the item you have just modified.

37. Recommended way to build a menu

It is best to start with a simple configuration.

For example:

1. Create one main menu.
2. Add one action.
3. Save the file.
4. Restart REAPER.
5. Check that the action works.

Then gradually add:

- more actions;
- separators;
- submenus;
- scripts;
- additional main menus.

This makes it much easier to identify the source of a problem.

38. Summary

Installation

Place:

`reaper_ReaCustomMenu.dll`

in:

REAPER resource folder\UserPlugins

and:

ReaCustomMenu.xml

in:

REAPER resource folder

The easiest way to find this folder is:

REAPER → Options → Show REAPER resource path in explorer/finder

XML Notepad

XML Notepad is free and available for Windows.

It can be downloaded from the official Microsoft project.

Creating menus

To add an element:

"Insert" → "Element" → "Child"

To add an attribute:

"Insert" → "Attributes" → "Child"

For each command

Use the Command ID corresponding to the action you want to run.

After each modification

Save ReaCustomMenu.xml and restart REAPER.

39. Example final organization

A personal configuration might eventually look like this:

Mixing

Open Mixer

FX

EQ

Compressor

Limiter

My Mixing Tools

MIDI

- Quantize
- Humanize
- MIDI Editing

Scripts

- My Scripts
 - Cleanup
 - Export
 - Utilities

You are free to choose the names, commands and organization that match the way you work.

ReaCustomMenu simply turns this organization into menus directly accessible from REAPER's main menu bar.